

Anti-War Sentiment in Popular Music Lyrics During the Vietnam War

Introduction

Music is not only entertainment. It can also be used as a historical source, because lyrics often show what people were concerned about at a specific time. During the 1960s and early 1970s, the Vietnam War became one of the most controversial events in American society. Many young people were drafted into the army, television showed images from the war, and public trust in politicians weakened. In this period, popular music became an important way to express protest, frustration, and political criticism.

This analysis looks at how popular music lyrics reflected anti-war sentiment and political protest during the Vietnam War era between 1965 and 1975. The central research question is: how did protest music express opposition to war and political authority, and how can digital methods help analyse this development? It argues how protest music developed from indirect critique of the war, into vocal political opposition as the Vietnam War progressed. Early songs often relied on symbolic and universal language, while later songs increasingly used direct and emotionally charged expressions of frustration, inequality, and resistance.

Based on existing research, it can be expected that earlier protest songs rely more on indirect and symbolic language, while later songs use more direct and emotionally charged expressions. By combining close reading with digital text analysis in RStudio, this paper demonstrates how these changes can be identified systematically across a small corpus of song lyrics.

The topic is relevant for a course on Digital Archives and Methods because it combines cultural history with digital source work. Lyrics from online databases can be treated as a small digital archive, and RStudio can be used to analyse words and themes across the selected songs. This makes it possible to connect traditional historical interpretation with digital humanities methods.

Sources and Digital Archives

The main primary sources for the following are lyrics from well-known protest songs from the Vietnam War era. Examples include Bob Dylan's "Blowin' in the Wind," Creedence Clearwater Revival's "Fortunate Son," Edwin Starr's "War," John Lennon's "Give Peace a Chance," and Crosby, Stills, Nash & Young's "Ohio." These songs were chosen because they are historically important and because they represent different forms of protest music.

The lyrics can be collected from digital lyric databases such as Genius and AZLyrics. These websites are not traditional archives in the same way as a state archive, but they still function as digital collections of cultural material. Chart information from Billboard can also be used to show whether the songs reached a wider audience. This is important because a protest song that entered popular culture had a different historical meaning than a song only known in small activist circles.

Digitized music journalism can also be useful. Rolling Stone and old issues of Billboard Magazine can provide context about how music was discussed at the time. These sources can show how artists were presented as political voices, and how protest songs were received by critics and audiences.

However, the use of digital archives such as Genius or AZLyrics also creates problems. Lyrics databases may include transcription mistakes, and they often focus on famous artists. This means that lesser-known protest singers may be missing. Because of this, the source material does not represent all protest music from the Vietnam period. It mainly represents protest music that became well-known and is still easy to find online today.

Method: Using RStudio for Text Analysis

The method used is a simple word frequency analysis in RStudio. The goal is not to explain the evolution of lyrics with numbers and data, but to use the code as a tool for finding patterns in the lyrics. Due to the limited scope of this paper, the analysis focuses on a small selection of eleven well-known protest songs rather than attempting to analyse all protest music from the period. The lyrics are placed in a CSV file with columns for song title, artist, year, and lyrics. RStudio can then split the lyrics into individual words, remove common stop words, and count which words appear most often.

This makes the analysis more systematic, as it looks at all the lyrics instead of singular selected lines. Instead of only choosing a few lines that support the argument, the code helps show which words are common across the whole corpus. For example, if words such as “war,” “peace,” “people,” “fight,” and “freedom” appear often, this supports the idea that the songs share a political vocabulary, to further their meaning and goals.

The following code was used in RStudio to generate the word frequency plot:

```
# Load packages  
library(tidyverse)  
library(tidytext)  
  
# Load the lyrics file  
lyrics <- read.csv("lyrics.csv")  
  
# Turn lyrics into single words  
words <- lyrics %>%  
  unnest_tokens(word, lyrics)
```

```
# Remove common words such as "the", "and", "is"
```

```
data("stop_words")
```

```
clean_words <- words %>%
```

```
  anti_join(stop_words, by = "word")
```

```
# Count the most common words
```

```
word_counts <- clean_words %>%
```

```
  count(word, sort = TRUE)
```

```
# Show the 20 most common words
```

```
head(word_counts, 20)
```

```
# Make a simple graph of the 15 most common words
```

```
word_counts %>%
```

```
  slice_max(n, n = 15) %>%
```

```
  ggplot(aes(x = reorder(word, n), y = n)) +
```

```
  geom_col() +
```

```
  coord_flip() +
```

```
  labs(title = "Most common words in protest song lyrics",
```

```
        x = "Word",
```

```
        y = "Frequency")
```

The CSV file could, as an example, look like this:

```
song,artist,year,lyrics
```

```
Fortunate Son,Creedence Clearwater Revival,1969,"Some folks are born made to wave the flag..."
```

```
War,Edwin Starr,1970,"War, what is it good for..."
```

```
Ohio,Crosby Stills Nash and Young,1970,"Tin soldiers and Nixon coming..."
```

The chosen songs for this, which includes Fortunate Son by Creedence Clearwater Revival, Give Peace a Chance by John Lennon, 21st Century Schizoid Man by King Crimson and more, were all

either influential or topped the US Billboard during release or in the war. *Fortunate Son*¹ and *Give Peace a Chance*², as an example, both peaked at number 14 on the US Billboard Hot 100 when released in September and July of 1969.

As shown in Figure 1, the word “war” appears significantly more frequently than any other term in the dataset. This lines up with the claim that protest music focused more and more on direct political critique. Other frequently occurring words, such as “dead,” “blown,” and “fight,” show the association between protest lyrics and themes of violence and destruction.

Furthermore, the presence of words such as “god” and “lord” suggests that some songs draw on religious language, possibly expressing hope or searching for meaning in a time of crisis. Similarly, the frequent use of the word “friend” may reflect a sense of solidarity, almost suggesting that protest music not only criticized the war but also helped construct a shared identity among listeners.

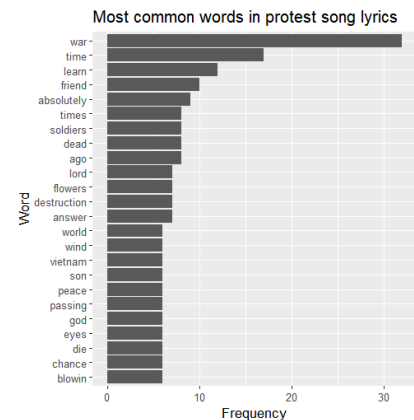


Figure 1

This approach treats song lyrics as a small digital corpus, allowing them to be analysed both qualitatively and quantitatively. The use of RStudio does not replace traditional historical interpretation, but it supports it by identifying patterns in language that may not be immediately visible through close reading alone.

The dataset includes 11 protest songs released between the early 1960s and early 1970s, which were critical of the war.

Historical Context

The Vietnam War became increasingly unpopular in the United States during the 1960s³. The war was connected to the Cold War, but many Americans began to question why the United States was fighting in Vietnam. The military draft made the conflict personal for many young men, and this helped create a strong anti-war movement.

At the same time, American society was already experiencing major social change. The civil rights movement challenged racial inequality, student groups protested against political authority, and countercultural movements rejected traditional values. Music became closely connected to these changes⁴. Folk and rock musicians were able to communicate political messages in a form that was emotional, memorable, and easy to share.

¹ Billboard, Creedence Clearwater Revival, <https://www.billboard.com/artist/creedence-clearwater-revival/chart-history/hsi/>

² Billboard, John Lennon, <https://www.billboard.com/artist/john-lennon/chart-history/hsi/>

³ Mueller, John, 1984, Vietnam as History, <https://politicalscience.osu.edu/faculty/jmueller/BRAESTRU.htm>

⁴ Brummer, Justin, 25.09.2018, The Vietnam War: A History in Song, History Today <https://www.historytoday.com/miscellanies/vietnam-war-history-song>

The growth of mass media also mattered. Radio, television, records, and music magazines helped spread protest songs to a large audience. This meant that political ideas could move through popular culture, not only through speeches, newspapers, or political organizations. Protest music therefore became part of the public debate about the war.

Analysis

Early Protest Songs: Moral Questions and Indirect Criticism

Early protest music often used broad moral questions instead of direct political attacks. Bob Dylan's "Blowin' in the Wind" is a good example. The song does not mention Vietnam directly, but it asks questions about peace, freedom, and death. Because the lyrics are open and symbolic, the song could be connected to different political movements, including civil rights and anti-war activism.

This kind of protest is powerful because it does not depend on one specific event. Instead, it presents war and injustice as moral problems. The song asks the listener to think about suffering and responsibility. In this way, it reflects a period when protest music was still often general and idealistic.

Dylan's "The Times They Are a-Changin'" also focuses on broader social change. It presents a conflict between younger and older generations and suggests that traditional authority is losing control. The song is political, but it is not only about the Vietnam War. It reflects the wider feeling that American society was changing.

A word frequency analysis of early protest lyrics would likely show many general terms, such as "people," "time," "change," and "freedom." These words show that early protest music often focused on universal values. It was critical, but not always directly anti-government or anti-war.

Later Protest Songs: Direct Anti-War Language

As the Vietnam War continued, protest music became more direct. Creedence Clearwater Revival's "Fortunate Son" from 1969 criticizes the unfairness of the draft. The song argues that wealthy and powerful people could avoid fighting, while ordinary Americans were sent to war. This makes the song not only anti-war, but also a criticism of class inequality.

The song's repeated rejection of elite privilege makes it very different from earlier symbolic protest songs. It points to a specific social problem: the unequal burden of military service. This shows how protest music could connect foreign policy to domestic inequality.

Edwin Starr's "War" from 1970 is even more direct. The song rejects war in simple and emotional language. Its message is easy to understand, which made it effective as a protest song. Unlike Dylan's earlier songs, "War" does not ask abstract questions. It gives a clear answer: war is destructive and useless.

The digital word frequency method would likely show that words such as "war," "fight," "kill," and "peace" become more important in later protest songs. This supports the argument that protest music became more explicit as the conflict continued.

Crosby, Stills, Nash & Young's "Ohio" is another important example. The song was written after the Kent State shootings in 1970, when four students were killed by the National Guard during a protest. The lyrics directly refer to political violence and mention Nixon. This makes the song almost like a musical newspaper article. It responds quickly to a specific event and turns it into cultural protest.

To show the evolution of the sentiment between the early and later stages of the war, the plotting of a sentiment analysis would be useful. The following code has been used in RStudio to show the evolution and sentiment in the lyrics, using the same fundamental code as in the word analysis:

```
# Get sentiment lexicon
bing <- get_sentiments("bing")

# Join with cleaned words
sentiment_words <- clean_words %>%
  inner_join(bing, by = "word")

# Count positive vs negative words
sentiment_count <- sentiment_words %>%
  count(sentiment)
```

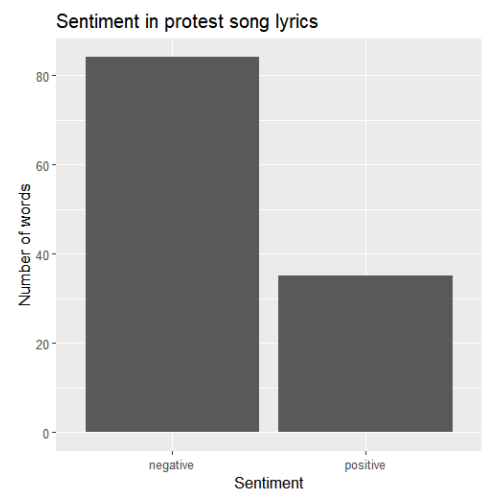


Figure 2

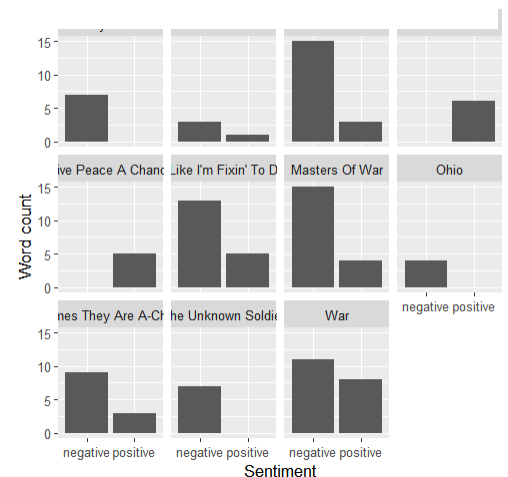


Figure 3

The sentiment analysis, shown in Figure 2, indicates a predominance of negative language across the selected songs. This fits the idea of protest music becoming more emotionally charged as the war goes on. That said, some songs do not follow this pattern. For example, "Give Peace a Chance" contains more positive language, showing a more hopeful and collective message. In contrast, songs such as "Fortunate Son" use more negative and often sarcastic language, expressing cynicism toward political and social inequality. It is important to note that sentiment analysis has clear limitations. Words are classified as positive or negative without considering context, tone, or irony. Therefore, the results should be interpreted cautiously and used only as supporting evidence rather than definitive conclusions.

As shown in Figure 3, there is variation between songs, with some containing more positive language than others. However, negative sentiment remains dominant across most songs, particularly in later protest music.

The sentiment analysis suggests that elements of negative language were already present in earlier protest songs. However, due to the limited dataset, this observation should be interpreted cautiously and cannot be taken as representative of all protest music before 1965.

Music as Mobilization

Protest music did not only reflect the various political attitudes of the time, it also helped shape the collective ideas and frustrations. Songs were performed at demonstrations, shared through mass media, and used as tools for collective expression. In this sense, music functioned both as a representation of protest and as an active part of the anti-war movement.

This shows that music was not just a reflection of the anti-war movement. It was also part of the movement's activity. Songs helped people feel connected to each other and gave them a shared language of protest.

Digital archives can help historians study this by connecting lyrics with chart data, interviews, and music journalism. If a protest song was popular on the charts, it suggests that anti-war messages reached beyond small activist groups. This makes popular music an important source for understanding how political ideas circulated in society.

Discussion: Strengths and Limits of the Digital Method

The RStudio analysis is useful because it makes the study of lyrics more systematic. It can show which words appear often and make it easier to compare several songs. This gives the paper a digital methods element and shows how historical sources can be analysed as data.

However, the method also has limits. A word frequency graph cannot explain irony, tone, or musical performance. It cannot show how an audience reacted to a song. It also cannot explain the full meaning of a lyric line. For example, the word "peace" may appear often, but one must still interpret how the word is used.

The digital archive also shapes the result. If the corpus only includes famous songs, then the analysis mostly shows mainstream protest music. It does not necessarily show what all anti-war musicians were singing. This means that the dataset must be described clearly and critically. Therefore, combining digital analysis with close reading remains important for actual historical interpretation. This is where using analytical tools with digital methods are effective for finding patterns across multiple texts, or in this case lyrics, but not as effective for interpreting meaning without context analysis.

Conclusion

Popular music was an important part of anti-war protest during the Vietnam War era. Between 1965 and 1975, protest lyrics moved from broad moral criticism toward more direct political and anti-war language. Early songs such as "Blowin' in the Wind" used symbolic questions about peace and justice, while later songs such as "Fortunate Son," "War," and "Ohio" criticized war, inequality, and government power more openly.

Digital methods help make this development visible. By using RStudio to count and visualize recurring words, it becomes possible to analyse protest lyrics as a small digital corpus. This does

not replace traditional historical analysis, but it supports it by showing patterns across several songs.

The limitation is that song lyrics cannot be understood only as data. They are also performances, cultural products, and political statements. Their meaning depends on historical context, audience reception, and musical form. Still, when digital methods are combined with close reading, protest songs become valuable sources for understanding the relationship between music, politics, and public protest during the Vietnam War.

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